

Miners Are Hot After Solving Pitching Problems

By JIM SLEEPER

Coach Andy Cohen's University of Texas at El Paso baseball Miners have caught fire and solved pitching problems to overcome an early season draught in victories.

"Early in the season was bad for control but our front line four pitchers — Lynn Hunt, Jesse Lujan, Ken McAnally and Don Wilson — have all caught fire and we have worked early season kinks out," Cohen says.

THE MINERS are not expecting any post season series invitations but will accept them if offered. "We did poorly at the start and our record is not that good but we will give any post season teams a battle," Cohen adds.

The top collegiate teams come from Arizona and New Mexico, with California following, and the Miners have faced already five of those teams in 18 games, winning and losing against both the defending NCAA champions and the NAIA champions.

Bulk of Cohen's talent is locally produced which makes it surprising that he has done as well due to the large amount of recruiting Arizona, New Mexico and New Mexico Highlands have done to give them nationally recognized diamond squads.

BY FAR THE top player — according to the scouts in pro baseball — at U.T.-El Paso is All-American griddler Charley West who has been drafted on three separate occasions and offered big bonuses which he has turned down to complete a college education.

West plays in the outfield and last year was second in batting with a .366 average which included 10 homeruns and 48 RBI's during a 38 game schedule. This year he is down on the batting but as a gloveman, hard to compare, with, because of a tremendous eye and speed.

ROUNDING OUT the outfield are a couple of veterans. Mike Ward has been playing left field and hitting the bat with authori-

ty. The junior transfer student from Roswell, N.M., is batting over .300 and filling the glove spot well. In right field is sophomore John Murphy from El Paso who trades off sometimes with Sam McClellan, a freshman batter, and Ron Rush, a transfer from Midland.

Taking the infield spots are first baseman John Miller, a .336 batter last year who has come up with doubles and homers to pull the Miners into the win circle in the last inning on three separate occasions; Juan Sandoval, another .300 plus hitter at second base and a sophomore returnee off last year's winning squad; shortstop Bob Aguirre who brings up experience and another good bat with a .300 plus average; and Danny Blanco, leading this year's stickmen and playing third base for his third straight year.

ANOTHER MAN who has helped in the infield this year is Kevin Berger, a freshman El Pasoan who plays first base and put on a good performance during a spell of absence by Miller with an injury.

Playing in the hot box and wielding a hot stick is Dallas transfer junior Ron Hix with Dick Meyer relieving as a catcher.

MOUND DUTY has been shared with Lynn Hunt and Jesse Lujan manning the starting spots and Ken McAnally, Bill Onick, Ernie Carreon and Don Wilson providing the majority of third game starting and relieving performances.

Cohen is an old pro in the baseball racket and has Kruschwitz as his assistant. The baseball Miners have been in existence for a short six years and have the same coaching staff as when they started.

TO IMPROVE, according to Cohen, the college is going to have to start recruiting more players of great potential and experience. Both Cohen and Kruschwitz coach without taking a dime in pay and are the type that many colleges enlarging their baseball program are looking for.

Due to the fast rise in attendance and growth in sports, more money is being allocated to the baseball program and other minor sports at the college and the caliber of play is close to the best in the nation now.

20 Game Winner Fails on Shutout

NEW YORK — Detroit Tiger pitcher Earl Wilson, who posted a 22-11 record in 1967, is the first 20-game winner since Alex Kellner in 1949 (20-12 for the Philadelphia Athletics) not to pitch a shutout during the season, according to an article in the current issue of SPORT Magazine.

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